

The serial blasts in Ahmedabad, totalling 17, were the highest so far in India's tryst with terrorism, more than the Mumbai explosions of 1993 which marks the birth of Islamic terror. They also revealed the daunting threat of a wider network of jihadis than was earlier believed, with the ability to strike anywhere, anytime, while an impotent government and incompetent police force looked on helplessly.

The unexploded bombs that were defused in public places in Surat and Ahmedabad in the aftermath of the Bangalore blasts on July 25 only demonstrated the magnitude of the challenge, starkly underlined by the fact that five days after Black Friday in Bangalore, the investigating agencies had not been able to arrest a single person directly connected to the dual attacks. And, if the public had any faith in the Government's ability to counter the growing threat, it quickly dissipated in the political one-upmanship that recorded a new low with BJP leader Sushma Swaraj accusing the Government of staging the attacks to divert attention from the trust vote.

If that marked a new low in political unity in the face of an increasingly dangerous threat, the blasts themselves showed a new high on the part of the perpetrators, planners and their sponsors. Bangalore may have got off lightly—just one death and nine injured—and so did Surat by some miracle, but the choice of Ahmedabad as a target sends a daunting message: it has been on the jihadi radar ever since the 2002 Gujarat riots.

That the terrorists are now emboldened by the Government's inability to counter the threat was starkly underlined by the email sent by the 'Indian Mujahideen', which intelligence officials say is the new name assumed by Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI), the outlawed militant outfit. The mail was received by various news channels five minutes before the Ahmedabad

AFTERMATH OF TRAGEDY:
Blast victims in the Civil Hospital, Ahmedabad



SHAILESH RAVAL

Instruments

MUMBAI, Aug 25, 2003

WHAT HAPPENED: Two blasts ripped through Zaveri Bazar and Gateway of India **DEATH TOLL: 46**

DEVICE USED: RDX packed in two taxis

STATUS: Solved, SIMI module busted

DELHI, Oct 29, 2005

WHAT HAPPENED: Three serial blasts rocked the capital before Diwali in crowded market places and a DTC bus.

DEATH TOLL: 62

DEVICE USED: IEDs in satchel

STATUS: Unsolved

VARANASI, March 7, 2006

WHAT HAPPENED: Three explosions including one at crowded Sankat Mochan temple and at a railway station

DEATH TOLL: 21

DEVICE USED: IEDs in pressure cookers

STATUS: Mastermind held

MUMBAI, July 11, 2006

WHAT HAPPENED: A series of seven bomb blasts struck six local trains at peak travel time in the evening

DEATH TOLL: 209

DEVICE USED: IEDs in pressure cookers

STATUS: Unsolved

MALEGAON, Sept 8, 2006

WHAT HAPPENED: Two bomb blasts ripped through the town in Nashik district in Maharashtra

DEATH TOLL: 40 **DEVICE USED:** IEDs on bicycles

STATUS: No arrest

PANIPAT, Feb 19, 2007

WHAT HAPPENED: Two IEDs went off on the New Delhi-Wagah Samjhauta Express just before midnight

DEATH TOLL: 66

DEVICE USED: Firebombs triggered by timer

STATUS: No arrest

HYDERABAD, May 18, 2007

WHAT HAPPENED: Twin blasts at the Mecca Masjid

DEATH TOLL: 12

DEVICE USED: Pipe bomb triggered by cell phone

STATUS: No arrest